ARCHITECTURE FOR ALL SEASONS

By Robert Campbell
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

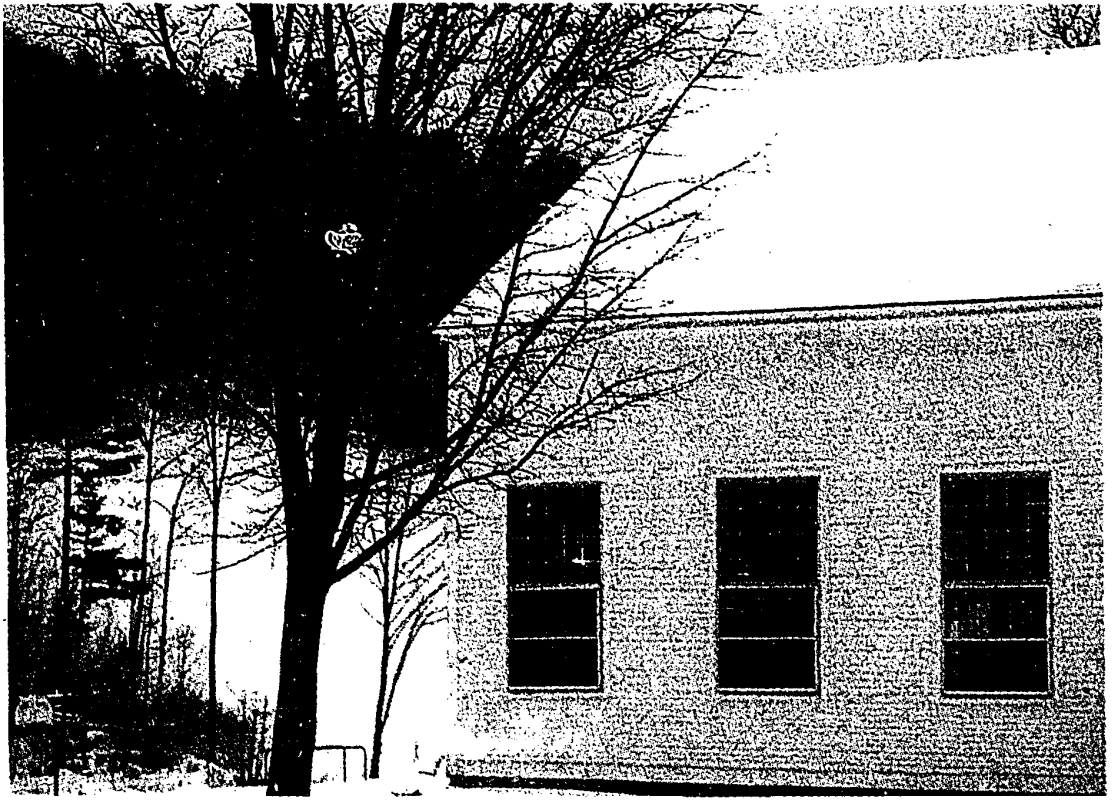
As this is written, New England is going through those terminal weeks of gloom that make our winter's end so dispiriting. A dreary light persists longer each day, and yet it seems the sun has not shone since the half-remembered golden weekends of October.

I suppose the chill gray air of March is bracing to the New England character. It revives our sense of nameless guilt, our belief that we are being punished for crimes we acknowledge but can't quite remember. Our weather, we believe, makes us sterner, sadder beings than the sun-drenched cavorters of Southern California.

We take pride in our New England gloom. But there are limits. Nature provides enough. It doesn't need help from architecture. Yet, too often our buildings seem to fortify the natural gloom, rather than relieve it.

Nothing, for example, looks worse on a March morning in New England than a

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GLOBE STAFF PHOTO / MICHELE MCDONALD

Clapboarding and mullions in Washington, N.H.: pleasing patterns, and a logic of place.

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building made of solid concrete. The grayness of the material seems to gather and focus the grayness of the air. If there has been rain, the concrete will be hideously streaked and stained. To view such a building is to experience a sinking of the heart. We seem to be in the presence of a vast mound of cold oatmeal.

Concrete buildings look much better in sunny climates. There the intense illumination tranforms them into bold sculptures of bright mass and dark void. But in New England, much of the time, they look ghastly.

That truth suggests an obvious question. Shouldn't architecture respond to the conditions of natural light that exist in a particular place?

Obviously, it should. And historically, it usually has.

Traditional New England architecture exhibits any number of characteristics that are perfectly adapted to New England light, qualities that make buildings look good in the haziest shade of winter. Clapboard siding, for example. Clapboard presents a surface that is boldly ruled in horizontal lines, regardless of whether the sun is shining. The pattern is always present, gray March or bright August.



GLOBE STAFF PHOTO / MICHELE MCDONALD

Brickwork in the Back Bay: the strength of regular rhythms, the rightness of tracery ornament.

Brick and white windows

Brick is another traditional New England material that maintains its pattern – a grid of mortar joints, in this case – regardless of the light. Red brick also has the kind of deep color that looks richer and more saturated in gloom than it does in sun (though it also glows with a special eloquence in the low ruddy sun of a New England autumn).

When you see a brick wall in New England, you also see, almost invariably, white window frames and mullions. The rhythmic march of these bold white rectangles across the red brick creates a larger pattern, one that, once again, reads clearly in gray light. In Harvard Yard, for instance, a simple palette of red walls, white windows and green doors, seen against a tracery of black twigs, is a perfect response to the winter gloom. In the depth of winter, the patch of green of a Harvard door is a memory and promise of summer.

Harvard buildings wouldn't look good in, say, Albuquerque. The intense glare of the desert sun would bleach the colors and flatten the patterns. And the broad expanse of the Western landscape would dwarf any intricacy of detail. So in Albuquerque, people build, traditionally, in adobe, a material whose simple mass and subdued earth-tone color can hold its own against so much sun and space. Adobe buildings are speckled with the shadows of deep openings for doors and windows, shadows that create variety and interest. In the even gray light of a Boston winter, those dark voids would disappear. Adobe in Boston would look like damp mud. What is right for one kind of light is wrong for another.

Another trait of New England architecture responds not so much to the quality of light as to the threat of cold and storm. Our traditional buildings look tightly zippered up against the weather. They're simple in overall shape, without a lot of projections or overhangs to tempt the wind or nurture icicles. Windows are smallish and are flush with the outside plane of the wall, so that window and wall can wrap the building in a single tight, seamless skin. Roofs pitch to shed rain. Clapboards, overlapping, are visibly watertight. Looking at a typical New England building on these dreary days of March, we feel satisfaction at its weather tightness. We sense its logic and rightness for this place. The architecture implies the climate.

Weather has something to do, too, with the kind of architectural ornament you find in New England. There isn't a lot of it, for one thing. The lavish wrought-iron work of New Orleans, or the richly colonnaded porches of the mansions of Natchez, wouldn't feel right among the snowdrifts of the Northeast. Yet ornament is essential if we are to have anything interesting to look at when there is neither sun nor shadow. New England ornament tends to be delicate, flat and linear. It is tracery rather than sculpture because sculpture demands sunlight. New England ornament is the fanlight over a Federal door. It is the shallow carved wood of a Greek Revival pediment. It is the incised names on the facade of the Boston Public Library.

Architects often say that there's no way to design a New England building because there's no single New England style of architecture. And, of course, that's true. But there is a New England style of light and weather. If a building is going to look good in March, it had better pay attention to that reality.

Robert Campbell is the Globe's architecture critic.

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